

Session 5: God Calls Avram and Promises Blessing

Key Takeaways

- Avram's call is framed in the language of Genesis 1-2, and it prepares the reader for the themes in the rest of his story—blessing, birth, land, family, and a great name.
- Avram leaving his family echoes Genesis 2:24 and the blessing of fruitful multiplication.
- God promises to make Avram's name great, further developing the theme of names or naming introduced in various stories in Genesis 1-11.

Macro Design of Genesis 12:1-9

Genesis 12:1-3

A - Yahweh's first word to Avram: Blessing and offspring

Genesis 12:4-6

B - Avram's response: Travel to Canaan

Genesis 12:7

A' - Yahweh's second word to Avram: Promise of land for offspring

Genesis 12:8-9

B' - Avram's response: Build an altar and travel to the Negev

Genesis 12:1-9. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Avram Leaves Babylon and Receives God's Blessing

The narrative sequence of two divine calls and promises, each followed by Avram's obedience, creates a clear pattern for the reader. When God's chosen one follows the divine command despite many unknowns, there is a blessing just waiting to be discovered.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 12:1-3

Part 2: Avram's Journey

Blessing and Children in the Promised Land

- 12:1 And Yahweh said to Avram,
a "Get yourself going
b from your land,
b' and from your family,
b' and from your father's house ,
a' to the land which I will show you.
-
- a 2 And I will make you a great nation ,
b and I will bless you,
a' and I will make your name great;
b' and so you shall be a blessing.
a 3 And I will bless
b those who bless you,
b' and the one who treats you as cursed
a' I will curse;
a and in you all the families of the land
b will find blessing."

Genesis 11:27-12:5. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

Get Yourself Going!

The Hebrew phrase for "get yourself going" (לֵךְ לְךָ) in 12:1 is unique, and it's repeated again only at the culmination of Avram's 10 tests in 22:2.

Genesis 12:1 Instructor's Translation

Get yourself going from your land ... to the land that I will show you.

Genesis 22:2 Instructor's Translation

Get yourself going to the land of Moriah, and offer [Yitskhaq] there as a going-up offering on one of the mountains that I will tell you.

Avram's New Family

Avram separates from his family and goes to a new place where God will create a new family. This is a repetition of the Eden pattern where God split the lone human into two humans to create the first chosen family. According to Genesis 2, only God can provide the necessary "help" (עֶזֶר) that can deliver his chosen one from helplessness.

Genesis 2:18 Instructor's Translation

It is not good for the human to be alone. I will make a source of **delivering-help** (עֶזֶר) that corresponds to the human.

Genesis 2:24 Instructor's Translation

For this reason, **a man will leave his father and mother**, and he will be joined to his wife, and the two will become one flesh.

Genesis 12:1 Instructor's Translation

Get yourself going ... from your land, from your birth-family and **from the house of your father** ...

Genesis 12:7 Instructor's Translation

To your **seed** (זֶרַע) I will give this land.

In both narratives, God's promise is to provide what the humans cannot provide for themselves. In Genesis 2, it's the "delivering help" ('ezer, עֶזֶר) without which the human cannot flourish in Eden, and in Genesis 12, it's the "seed" (zera', זֶרַע) without which Avram's family cannot become a blessing to the nations.

Greatness and Blessing

Genesis 12:2 Instructor's Translation

And I will make you a great nation, and I will bless you,
and I will make your name great; and so you shall be a blessing.

The two parallel poetic lines contain two promises of greatness and two promises of blessing.

- Great nation / Great name
- I will bless you / You will be a blessing

This first pair of lines highlights what God will do for Avram (make great and bless), while the second item highlights what Avram will become in relationship to others.

- Great name = a significant reputation among the nations
- "Be a blessing" = Avram is summoned to become a conduit of the divine blessing he received as he gives it out to the nations around him

These poetic lines create a vocation for Avram. He is being summoned to a new Eden-like land where God will create him into a new chosen family where he can become a channel of divine blessing to others. This vocation is the focus of the final lines of the poem.

Genesis 12:3 Instructor's Translation

And I will bless
those who bless you,
and the one who treats you as cursed
I will curse;

and in you all the families of the land
will find blessing.”

Here, God marks Avram as his chosen one and commits to protecting him from death. The promise comes in two parts.

1. As a conduit of God’s blessing, those who associate with Avram in a friendly way will receive God’s blessing.
2. On the flip side, those who “treat him as cursed” (מקלל, from קלל “to treat as insignificant”) will receive the opposite, “curse.”

Avram as a New Adam and Noah

The divine promise of blessing corresponds to the divine blessing first given to humanity and then to Noah after the flood.

Genesis 1:27-28 Instructor’s Translation

²⁷ *Elohim* created humanity in his image, in the image of *Elohim* he created him; male and female he created them. ²⁸ And *Elohim* **blessed** them; and *Elohim* said to them, “Be fruitful and multiply, and fill the earth, and subdue it; and rule over the fish of the sea and over the birds of the sky and over every living thing that moves on the earth.”

Genesis 9:1-2 Instructor’s Translation

¹ And *Elohim* **blessed** Noah and his sons and said to them, “Be fruitful and multiply, and fill the earth. ² The fear of you and the terror of you will be on every beast of the earth and on every bird of the sky; with everything that creeps on the ground, and all the fish of the sea, into your hand they are given.”

Genesis 12:2-3 Instructor’s Translation

² and I will make you a great nation, and I will **bless** you, and I will make your name great; and so you shall be a **blessing**; ³ and I will **bless** those who **bless** you, and the one who treats you as cursed I will curse; and in you all the clan-families of the land will find **blessing**.

The poem of blessing in 12:2-3 has five blessings that interestingly correspond to the five curses in Genesis 1-11, and it has seven poetic lines that correspond to the later blessings given to the patriarchs, which also consist of seven parts (Cassuto, Umberto (2012). [From Noah to Abraham](#). Varda Books. 331).

Genesis 12:2-3 Instructor’s Translation

1. and I will make you a great nation
2. and I will **bless** you,
3. and I will make your name great;
4. and so you shall be a **blessing**;
5. and I will **bless** those who **bless** you,
6. and the one who treats you as cursed I will curse;
7. and in you all the clan-families of the land will find **blessing**.

The five curses of Genesis 3-11

- Gen. 3:14 “**cursed!** are you” (snake)
- Gen. 3:17 “**cursed!** is the ground because of you” (man)
- Gen. 3:14 “**cursed!** are you from the ground” (Cain)
- Gen. 3:14 “the ground which Yahweh has **cursed!**”
- Gen. 3:14 “**cursed!** is Canaan”

“The whole Bible can be portrayed as a very long answer to a very simple question: What can God do about the sin and rebellion of the human race? Genesis 12-Revelation 22 is God’s answer to the problem posed by the bleak narratives of Genesis 3-11. Or ... Genesis 3-11 sets the problem that the mission of God addresses from Genesis 12 onward. Genesis 1-11 poses a cosmic problem to which God must provide a cosmic answer. The problems so graphically spread before the reader in Genesis 1-11 will not be solved just by finding a way to get human beings to heaven when they die. The love and power of the Creator must address not only the sin of individuals, but also the strife and hostility of nations; not only the needs of humans, but also the suffering on animals and the curse on the ground ... The call of Abram is the beginning of God’s answer to the evil of human hearts, the strife of nations, and the groaning brokenness of his whole creation.”

Wright, Christopher (2006). [*The Mission of God: Unlocking the Bible’s Grand Narrative*](#). IVP Academic. 195.

Avram

Genesis 12:2-3 Instructor’s Translation

1. and I will make you a great nation
2. and I will **bless** you,
3. and I will make your name great;
4. and so you shall be a **blessing**;
5. and I will **bless** those who **bless** you,
6. and the one who treats you as cursed I will curse;
7. and in you all the clan-families of the land will find **blessing**.

Isaac

Genesis 26:3-4 Instructor’s Translation

1. and I will be with you,
2. and I will bless you,
3. for to you and to your descendants I will give all these lands,
4. and I will fulfil the oath which I swore to Avraham your father.
5. I will multiply your descendants as the stars of heaven,
6. and will give to your descendants all these lands;
7. and by your descendants all the nations of the earth shall bless themselves.

Jacob

Genesis 27:28-29 Instructor’s Translation

1. May God give you of the dew of heaven, etc.
2. Let peoples serve you,
3. and nations bow down to you.
4. Be lord over your brothers,
5. and may your mother's sons bow down to you.
6. Cursed be every one who curses you,
7. and blessed be every one who blesses you!

Relationship to Juxtaposed Sections

Avram's journey to Canaan is actually a completion of what his father Terakh left undone back in 11:31. Avram's actions are clearly set in contrast to his father.

Genesis 11:31 NASB

Terah took Abram his son, and Lot the son of Haran, his grandson, and Sarai his daughter-in-law, his son Abram's wife; and they went out together from Ur of the Chaldeans in order to enter the land of Canaan; and they went as far as Haran, and settled there.

Genesis 12:5 NASB

Abram took Sarai his wife and Lot his nephew, and all their possessions which they had accumulated, and the persons which they had acquired in Haran, and they set out for the land of Canaan; thus they came to the land of Canaan.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 12:6-9

Avram's Sojourn to Shechem

- a 6 **And Avram passed through (ויעבר)** **in the land**
b **unto the** place of Shechem
b' **unto the** oak of Moreh,
a' and the Canaanite was then **in the land**.

Worship + Altar for Yahweh

- a 7 And **Yahweh appeared to Avram** and he said,
b "To your seed I will give this land."
a' And **he built there an altar to Yahweh** **who appeared to him**.

Avram's Sojourn to Bethel

- a 8 **And he moved on (ויעתק)** from there
b to the hill **from the east** of **Bethel**,

a' and he spread out his tent,
b' **Bethel** on the west
b' and Ai **from the east**;

Worship + Altar for Yahweh

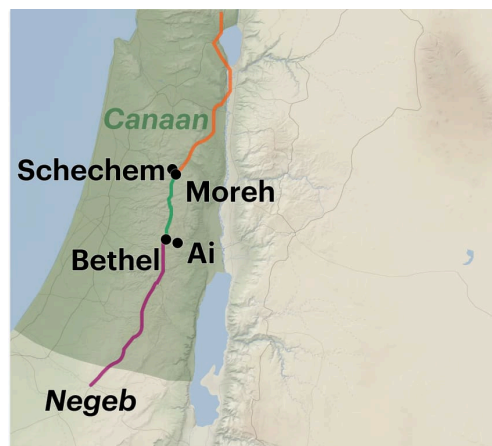
a and **he built there an altar to Yahweh**
a' and **he called upon the name of Yahweh.**

Avram's Sojourn to the Negev

a 9 **And Avram journeyed (ויסע)**,
a' continually **journeying (נסוע)** to the Negev.

Genesis 12:6-9. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

Map of Avram's First Migration in the Land of Canaan



[Openstreetmap.org](https://www.openstreetmap.org).

Avram enters Canaan from the north, and he passes along the hill country that runs from north to south with the coastal and Jordan River valleys on each side. As he does so, he makes a number of very interesting stops along the way.

Avram the Shepherd and the Canaanite Cities

Avram is portrayed as making three stops, the first two near hilltop towns central to the highway network in Canaan. The narrative highlights how he does not enter the cities populated with Canaanites. Instead, Avram sets up camp near the cities, and he builds new places of worship for the *Elohim* who called him to this land.

The narrative highlights how "the Canaanite was in the land at that time" to show us that Avram isn't integrating into Canaanite culture. Instead, he sets up his own alternative residence with unique places of worship dedicated to his *Elohim*.

Avram's Alternate Society

In this way, Avram is depicted along parallel lines to Abel and Seth, in contrast to Cain and Lemek.

Adam's Sons in Genesis 4	Noah's "Sons" in Genesis 12
Gen. 4:2-4 Abel was a "shepherd of the flock" and made offerings to Yahweh from his flock	Gen. 12:5, 16 Avram (from the line of Shem) leads a migrating shepherd caravan with many flocks
Gen. 4:26 Seth, the seed given in the place of Abel, has his first son, named <i>Enosh</i> (= "human"), when "it was begun, calling on the name of Yahweh."	Gen. 12:6, 8 Avram builds altars in Canaan and "calls upon the name of Yahweh"
Cain was a farmer (Gen. 4:1-4), who, after his murder of Abel the shepherd, went on to build the first city in the Bible and named it after his first son, <i>Khanok</i> (= "dedicated," Gen. 4:17)	Gen. 12:6 The Canaanites (from the line of Ham), in contrast to Avram, live in the cities
Adam's Sons and Noah's Sons. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).	

Avram becomes the new humanity from the line of Yahweh worshippers who are chosen and set apart from their urban siblings who worship manmade things (gods or cities). Avram will establish the worship of the creator God, and he begins by marking the central hill country as the territory of Yahweh.

Avram's Journey as a Foundation Pattern

Avram's three-stop journey through the promised land begins a pattern that is later mirrored by his grandson Yaaqov (Jacob) in Gen. 33-35, and yet again by Joshua and the Israelites (Josh. 7-8).

Avram	Jacob	Joshua (After Stop #1: Jericho)
Stop #1: Shechem Gen. 12:6-7 And Avram passed through in the land until the place of Shechem , unto the	Stop #1: Shechem Gen. 33:18, 20 And Jacob came safely to the city of Shechem , which is in the land	Stop #3: Shechem Josh. 8:30 Then Joshua built an altar to the Lord, the God of Israel, on Mount Ebal [just
Avram's Journey Pattern. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).		

Avram	Jacob	Joshua (After Stop #1: Jericho)
Terebinth of Vision ... And he built an altar there to Yahweh who appeared to him.	of Canaan, when he returned from Paddan-Aram, and he camped in front of the city ... And he set up a pillar there, and called it "El, the God of Israel."	outside Shechem, see Deut. 11:29-30]
Stop #2: Bethel Gen. 12:8 And he set out from there to the to the mountain east of Bethel (מקדם לבית אל), and he pitched his tent, with Bethel on the west and Ai on the east (מקדם). And he built there an altar to Yahweh and he called on the name of Yahweh.	Stop #2: Bethel Gen. 35:1 And God said to Jacob, "Get up, go up to Bethel and stay there and make there an altar to El who appeared to you when you fled from your brother Esau. Gen. 35:6-7 So Jacob came to Luz (that is, Bethel), which is in the land of Canaan ... And he built an altar there, and called the place El-bethel	Stop #2: Bethel Josh. 7:2 Now Joshua sent men from Jericho to Ai, which is near Beth-aven, east of Bethel (מקדם לבית אל), and said to them, "Go up and spy out the land." So the men went up and spied out Ai. Josh. 8:9 Joshua sent them away, and they went to the place of ambush and remained between Bethel and Ai (בין בית אל ובין העי), on the west side of Ai (מים לעי); but Joshua spent that night among the people.
Stop #3: The Negev Gen. 12:9 And Avram set out (ויסע) continuing and traveling to the Negev.	Stop #3: The Negev Gen. 35:27 Jacob came home to his father Isaac in Mamre, near Kiriath Arba (that is, Hebron), where Avraham and Isaac had stayed. Gen. 46:1 So Israel set out (ויסע) with all that he had, and came to Beersheba, and offered sacrifices to the God of his father Isaac.	Stop #4: The Negev Josh. 10:40 Thus Joshua struck all the land, the hill country and the Negev and the lowland and the slopes and all their kings. Josh. 11:16 Thus Joshua took all that land: the hill country and all the Negev, all that land of Goshen, the lowland, the Arabah, the hill country of Israel and its lowland
Avram's Journey Pattern. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).		

"Now we can understand why the Torah stressed, in all their detail, Abram's journeys on entering the land of Canaan, at first as far as Shekem, and subsequently up to Ai-Bethel. Scripture intended to present us here, through the symbolic conquest of Abram, with a kind of forecast of what would happen to his descendants later. According to this tradition the token was first given to Abram and afterwards repeated to Jacob, and the significance of the duplication is to corroborate and ratify, as the Bible itself makes clear when citing

the words of Joseph to Pharaoh (41:32): And the doubling of Pharaoh's dream means that the thing is fixed by God, and God will shortly bring it to pass. In conformity with this, the book of Joshua portrays for us the actual subjugation in a manner paralleling the ideal conquest by the Patriarchs—even the wording is similar—as though to say, the possession of the land gained in the days of Joshua was already implied, in essence, in the symbolic conquest that the first patriarchs had effected in their time, and that it was all predestined and foretold from the beginning in accordance with the Lord's will."

Cassuto, Umberto (2012). [From Noah to Abraham](#). Varda Books. 305-306.

The Promise of Land

Notice that at the center of 12:6-9 is the promise of land for Avram's family.

Worship + Altar for Yahweh

- a ⁷ And **Yahweh appeared to Avram** and he said,
b "To your seed I will give this land."
a' And **he built there an altar to Yahweh** **who appeared to him** .

Genesis 12:6-9. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

God's promise in 12:1-3 focused on the family that God would build from Avram and Sarai's lineage, and Avram was simply told to "go to the land that I will show you." Now that Avram has arrived in that land, the next part of God's promise is revealed: The land itself will become part of Avram's inheritance. This two-stage presentation of God's promise creates an important analogy between the two elements of God's promise.

Genesis 12:1-3

Divine Promise #1

- "Go to **the land** I will show you ... I will bless you and **make you a great nation.** "

Genesis 12:4-6

Avram Travels to the Land, Sets Up Altars to Yahweh

Genesis 12:7

Divine Promise #2

- "To **your seed** I will give **this land.** "

Genesis 12:8

Avram Travels to the Land, Sets Up Altars to Yahweh

This analogy between the promise of seed and land is foundational for the rest of the Avraham story. These two elements of God's promise become closely intertwined, each involving the other, so they become inseparable from each other. The promise of a family lineage requires a place for that family to live, and the promise of a land to inhabit assumes the existence of a family who will cultivate the land. In this way, the promise resembles the divine blessing given to Adam and Eve, which is certainly why the narrator highlights the fact that Avram makes his altars on high places near trees.

Avram's Sojourn to Shechem

- a 6 **And Avram passed through (ויעבר) in the land**
- b **unto the** place of Shechem
- b' **unto the** oak of Moreh,
- a' and the Canaanite was then **in the land**.

Worship + Altar for Yahweh

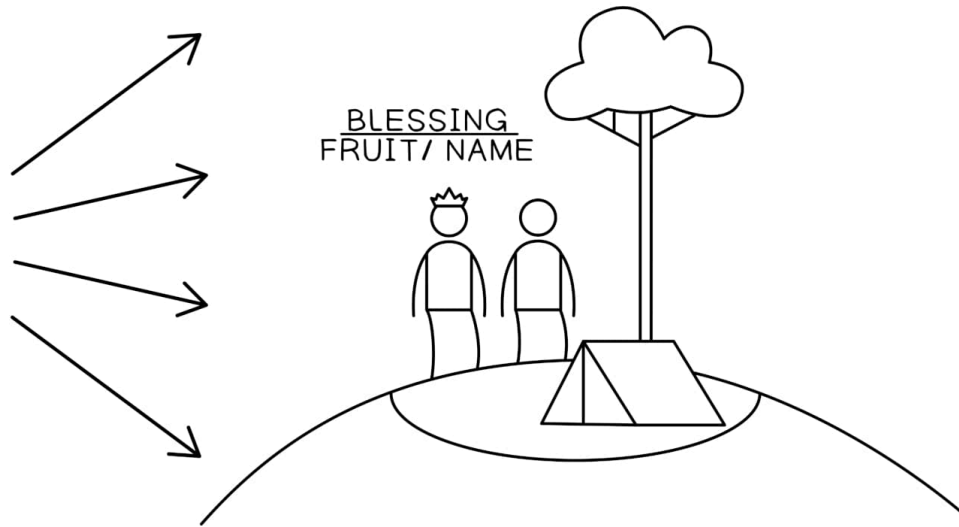
- a 7 And **Yahweh appeared to Avram** and he said,
- b "To your seed I will give this land."
- a' And **he built there an altar to Yahweh who appeared to him**.

Genesis 12:6-9. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

All of these words are built from the Hebrew root *ra'ah* (ראה) "to see." It's a not-so-subtle allusion to the trees of Eden, where the humans "saw" and had "their eyes opened" after a great failure to trust Yahweh's wisdom. Here Avram has his eyes opened to see Yahweh after his first act of trust in Yahweh's summons to leave his family and come to Canaan.

Blessing Out of the Scattering

SCATTER



Out of the Scattering. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Reflection Question

Contrast God promising to make Avram's name great with the architects of the tower of Babylon desiring to make a great name for themselves. What does this show us about God's character and what God desires to see in humans?